

Is the passover lamb a young sheep?

You may be surprised to find out that the answer is no - the passover lamb is most certainly not necessarily a young sheep. The first time the ordinance of the passover appears is in **Exodus** chapter 12:

Exodus 12:1-6

¹ And the LORD spake unto Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt, saying,

² This month *shall be* unto you the beginning of months: it *shall be* the first month of the year to you.

³ Speak ye unto all the congregation of Israel, saying, In the tenth *day* of this month they shall take to them every man a lamb^{H7716}, according to the house of *their* fathers, a lamb^{H7716} for an house:

⁴ And if the household be too little for the lamb^{H7716}, let him and his neighbour next unto his house take *it* according to the number of the souls; every man according to his eating shall make your count for the lamb^{H7716}.

⁵ Your lamb^{H7716} shall be without blemish, a male of the first year: ye shall take *it* out from the sheep^{H3532}, or from the goats^{H5795}.

⁶ And ye shall keep it up until the fourteenth day of the same month: and the whole assembly of the congregation of Israel shall kill it in the evening.

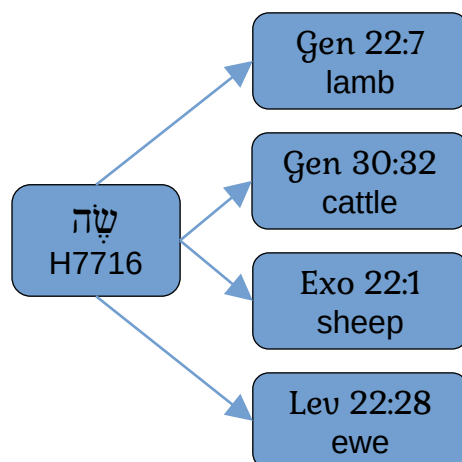
And so, God's definition of a "lamb" here is a sheep (ovine) or a goat (capra).

We could stop right there if we were only interested in this verse; but, there is so much more that we can learn from these verses but only if we dare dig deeper.

There are 8 Hebrew and 2 Greek words that God translated into the English word "lamb".

As we learned above, one way we can define a word with God's word is from the context itself; however, not only is that not always possible but also in order to obtain a more precise definition for a particular usage of a word we need to do more work. One way that we can do that is by looking behind the veil of translation. God's word was pure and perfect before it was translated to English and it remains pure and perfect afterward as well (**Psa 12:6,7**). Conveniently, we don't need to learn or know a single word of Hebrew or of Greek to do so.

The Hebrew word that "lamb" was translated from by God in the above verses was codified by Strongs (and others) as H7716. We will find God's definitions that are built-in to His own word by looking at what other English words the Holy Ghost translated H7716 (לֶמֶד) to in the Bible. The following is a simplified visual example of what we are looking at:



Here is a concise summary of the results for H7716 (the full summary is at the end of the document):

H7716	
cattle	10
ewe	1
lamb	17
sheep	18
<i>total</i>	46

As we can see above H7716 is translated as “cattle” in 10 different places. Here’s a few of them that teach us that when God uses the word cattle He does not mean just bovine.

Genesis 30:32

I will pass through all thy flock to day, removing from thence all the speckled and spotted cattle^{H7716}, and all the brown cattle^{H7716} among the sheep, and the spotted and speckled among the goats: and of such shall be my hire.

Sheep, goats.

Exodus 34:19

All that openeth the matrix is mine; and every firstling among thy cattle^{H4735}, whether ox or sheep^{H7716}, that is male.

Oxen, sheep, and goats.

Ezekiel 34:17

And as for you, O my flock, thus saith the Lord GOD; Behold, I judge between cattle^{H7716} and cattle^{H7716}, between the rams and the he goats.

Rams, oxen, sheep, and goats.

Leviticus 22:26-28

²⁶ And the LORD spake unto Moses, saying,

²⁷ When a bullock, or a sheep, or a goat, is brought forth, then it shall be seven days under the dam; and from the eighth day and thenceforth it shall be accepted for an offering made by fire unto the LORD.

²⁸ And whether it be cow^{H7794} or ewe^{H7716}, ye shall not kill it and her young both in one day.

Your Bible footnotes may say that an ewe is a female goat and/or that a cow is a female bovine. Since when do bovine give birth to goats?

Noah Webster's 1828 dictionary says that an ewe is a "A female sheep; the female of the ovine race of animals." (and that is only partly* true).

It also says that a cow is "The female of the bovine genus of animals;" (and that appears to always be true).

Looking carefully at every usage of "ewe" in God's word (except Lev 22:28) we can see that God uses it to describe "a less than 1 year old*, female sheep".

Did God forget that bovine do not give birth to ovine? Did He get His words mixed up? What's going on here?

Remember from the summary above that H7716 is translated as "ewe" one time? That one time is here in Lev 22:28. Remember also that H7716 is a more generic term for animals from the herd or flock (Lev 1:2, 22:27). Additionally, the word "young" in v28 modifies "ewe" such that the offspring could be male or female instead of primarily female as elsewhere (28a 12:3).

H7794 is translated to 7 different English words and it can mean a male or a female bovine. H7794 as "cow" only shows up twice: Lev 22:28 and Num 18:17 where it is specifically a female bovine.

And so when you put it all together in v28 "cow" is a female bovine and "ewe" is her offspring (a male or female bovine) and they are given as an example of the principle laid out in the verse that precedes it.

A female bovine (Lev 3:1) and her offspring (Lev 3:1, 22:27) are both possible offerings to the LORD, and in v28 He makes it clear that they are not to be offered on the same day. And of course v27 makes it clear that the young is to spend at least 7 days with its mother so then neither could be offered (without sinning) during that 7 day period. Moreover, that same principal also applies to ovine (sheep) and capra (goats).

And so, when you apply the right definitions from God's word itself, the verse makes perfect sense.

Cattle		Ewe		Lamb		Sheep	
9 Hebrew, 2 Greek		1 Hebrew		8 Hebrew, 2 Greek		7 Hebrew, 2 Greek	
Gen 1:24	H929	Lev 22:28	H7716	Gen 22:7	H7716	Gen 4:2	H6629
Gen 4:20	H4735			Exo 12:21	H6629	Gen 30:32	H3775
Gen 30:32	H7716			Exo 29:39	H3532	Exo 12:5	H3532
Gen 30:39	H6629			Lev 3:7	H3775	Exo 22:1	H7716
Gen 33:14	H4399			Lev 5:6	H3776	Num 31:43	H4480
Num 20:4	H1165			Lev 14:10	H3535	Num 32:24	H6792
1Ki 1:9	H4806			1Sa 7:9	H2924	Son 6:6	H7353
Joe 1:18	H1241			Isa 16:1	H3733	Mat 9:36	G4263
Zec 13:5	H7069			Joh 1:29	G286	Joh 5:2	G4262
Luke 17:7	G4165			Rev 5:6	G721		
Joh 4:12	G2353						

Gen 22:7	And Isaac spake unto Abraham his father, and said, My father: and he said, Here am I, my son. And he said, Behold the fire and the wood : but where is the lamb ^{H7716} for a burnt offering?
Gen 22:8	And Abraham said, My son, God will provide himself a lamb ^{H7716} for a burnt offering: so they went both of them together.
Gen 30:32	I will pass through all thy flock to day, removing from thence all the speckled and spotted cattle ^{H7716} , and all the brown cattle ^{H7716} among the sheep, and the spotted and speckled among the goats: and of such shall be my hire.
Exo 12:3	Speak ye unto all the congregation of Israel, saying, In the tenth day of this month they shall take to them every man a lamb ^{H7716} , according to the house of their fathers , a lamb ^{H7716} for an house:
Exo 12:4	And if the household be too little for the lamb ^{H7716} , let him and his neighbour next unto his house take it according to the number of the souls; every man according to his eating shall make your count for the lamb ^{H7716} .
Exo 12:5	Your lamb ^{H7716} shall be without blemish, a male of the first year: ye shall take it out from the sheep, or from the goats:
Exo 13:13	And every firstling of an ass thou shalt redeem with a lamb ^{H7716} ; and if thou wilt not redeem it, then thou shalt break his neck: and all the firstborn of man among thy children shalt thou redeem.
Exo 22:1	If a man shall steal an ox , or a sheep ^{H7716} , and kill it, or sell it; he shall restore five oxen for an ox, and four sheep for a sheep ^{H7716} .
Exo 22:4	If the theft be certainly found in his hand alive, whether it be ox, or ass , or sheep ^{H7716} ; he shall restore double.
Exo 22:9	For all manner of trespass, whether it be for ox, for ass , for sheep ^{H7716} , for raiment, or for any manner of lost thing, which another challengeth to be his, the cause of both parties shall come before the judges; and whom the judges shall condemn, he shall pay double unto his neighbour.
Exo 22:10	If a man deliver unto his neighbour an ass, or an ox , or a sheep ^{H7716} , or any beast, to keep; and it die, or be hurt, or driven away, no man seeing it:
Exo 34:19	All that openeth the matrix is mine; and every firstling among thy cattle, whether ox or sheep ^{H7716} , that is male.
Exo 34:20	But the firstling of an ass thou shalt redeem with a lamb ^{H7716} : and if thou redeem him not, then shalt thou break his neck. All the firstborn of thy sons thou shalt redeem. And none shall appear before me empty.
Lev 5:7	And if he be not able to bring a lamb ^{H7716} , then he shall bring for his trespass, which he hath committed, two turtledoves, or two young pigeons, unto the LORD; one for a sin offering, and the other for a burnt offering.
Lev 12:8	And if she be not able to bring a lamb ^{H7716} , then she shall bring two turtles, or two young pigeons; the one for the burnt offering, and the other for a sin offering: and the priest shall make an atonement for her, and she shall be clean.
Lev 22:23	Either a bullock or a lamb ^{H7716} that hath any thing superfluous or lacking in his parts, that mayest thou offer for a freewill offering; but for a vow it shall not be accepted.

Lev 22:28	And whether it be cow or ewe^{H7716} , ye shall not kill it and her young both in one day.
Lev 27:26	Only the firstling of the beasts, which should be the LORD'S firstling, no man shall sanctify it; whether it be ox , or sheep^{H7716} : it is the LORD'S.
Num 15:11	Thus shall it be done for one bullock, or for one ram , or for a lamb^{H3532} ^{H7716} , or a kid.
Deu 14:4	These are the beasts which ye shall eat: the ox , the sheep^{H7716} ^{H3775} , and the goat,
Deu 17:1	Thou shalt not sacrifice unto the LORD thy God any bullock , or sheep^{H7716} , wherein is blemish, or any evilfavouredness: for that is an abomination unto the LORD thy God.
Deu 18:3	And this shall be the priest's due from the people, from them that offer a sacrifice, whether it be ox or sheep^{H7716} ; and they shall give unto the priest the shoulder, and the two cheeks, and the maw.
Deu 22:1	Thou shalt not see thy brother's ox or his sheep^{H7716} go astray, and hide thyself from them: thou shalt in any case bring them again unto thy brother.
Jos 6:21	And they utterly destroyed all that was in the city, both man and woman, young and old, and ox , and sheep^{H7716} , and ass, with the edge of the sword.
Jdg 6:4	And they encamped against them, and destroyed the increase of the earth, till thou come unto Gaza, and left no sustenance for Israel , neither sheep^{H7716} , nor ox, nor ass.
1Sa 14:34	And Saul said, Disperse yourselves among the people, and say unto them, Bring me hither every man his ox, and every man his sheep^{H7716} , and slay them here, and eat; and sin not against the LORD in eating with the blood. And all the people brought every man his ox with him that night, and slew them there.
1Sa 15:3	Now go and smite Amalek, and utterly destroy all that they have, and spare them not; but slay both man and woman, infant and suckling, ox and sheep^{H7716} , camel and ass.
1Sa 17:34	And David said unto Saul, Thy servant kept his father's sheep, and there came a lion, and a bear, and took a lamb^{H7716} ^{H2089} out of the flock:
1Sa 22:19	And Nob, the city of the priests, smote he with the edge of the sword, both men and women, children and sucklings, and oxen, and asses , and sheep^{H7716} , with the edge of the sword.
Psa 119:176	I have gone astray like a lost sheep^{H7716} ; seek thy servant; for I do not forget thy commandments.
Isa 7:25	And on all hills that shall be digged with the mattock, there shall not come thither the fear of briers and thorns: but it shall be for the sending forth of oxen, and for the treading of lesser cattle^{H7716} .
Isa 43:23	Thou hast not brought me the small cattle^{H7716} of thy burnt offerings; neither hast thou honoured me with thy sacrifices. I have not caused thee to serve with an offering, nor wearied thee with incense.
Isa 53:7	He was oppressed, and he was afflicted, yet he opened not his mouth: he is brought as a lamb^{H7716} to the slaughter, and as a sheep before her shearers is dumb, so he openeth not his mouth.
Isa 66:3	He that killeth an ox is as if he slew a man; he that sacrificeth a lamb^{H7716} , as if he cut off a dog's neck; he that offereth an oblation, as if he offered swine's blood; he that burneth incense, as if he blessed an idol. Yea, they have chosen their own ways, and their soul delighteth in their abominations.

Jer 50:17	Israel is a scattered sheep ^{H7716} ; the lions have driven him away: first the king of Assyria hath devoured him; and last this Nebuchadrezzar king of Babylon hath broken his bones.
Eze 34:17	And as for you, O my flock, thus saith the Lord GOD; Behold, I judge between cattle ^{H7716} and cattle ^{H7716} , between the rams and the he goats.
Eze 34:20	Therefore thus saith the Lord GOD unto them; Behold, I, even I, will judge between the fat cattle ^{H7716} and between the lean cattle ^{H7716} .
Eze 34:22	Therefore will I save my flock, and they shall no more be a prey; and I will judge between cattle ^{H7716} and cattle ^{H7716} .
Eze 45:15	And one lamb ^{H7716} out of the flock, out of two hundred, out of the fat pastures of Israel; for a meat offering, and for a burnt offering, and for peace offerings, to make reconciliation for them, saith the Lord GOD.